

A grounded typology of vacation decision-making

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Abstract

This paper presents a typology of vacationers based on decision-making variables and processes. Employing a naturalistic perspective, the (summer) vacation decision-making process of 25 Belgian households was followed for a year. In-depth interview and observation data were analyzed and interpreted through the grounded theory methodology. Findings show that vacation decision-making is an ongoing process with a lot of contextual influences. A distinction is made between six types of vacationers: habitual, rational, hedonic, opportunistic, constrained and adaptable. This new typology may be useful for both theoretical and segmentation purposes.

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1. Introduction

The tourism literature has proposed a large number of typologies of vacationers, tourists and travelers. Many of these typologies are based on segmentation criteria (see Table 1), which have been proposed to sub-divide vacationers into homogeneous groups, in order to help targeting and positioning strategies. These criteria can be used separately or in combination (Lang & O'Leary, 1997). Widely used are demographic criteria, such as age (Anderson & Langmeyer, 1982), the family life cycle (Fodness, 1992) and vacationers' predispositions such as benefits sought (Shoemaker, 1994; Woodside & Jacobs, 1985). A lot of attention has also been given to behavioral variables, such as vacation activities (Hsieh, O'Leary, & Morrison, 1992; Moscardo, Morrison, Pearce, Lang, & O'Leary, 1996), amount of expenditure (Spotts & Mahoney, 1991), chosen destination (Lang et al., 1997), distance traveled (Etzel & Woodside, 1982) and frequency of travel (Woodside, Cook, & Mindak, 1987). More traditional geographical and economical criteria have been suggested as well (Swarbrooke & Horner, 1999).

Typologies based on segmentation criteria can be used for day-to-day marketing operations such as segmentation, targeting, destination selection, pricing, etc. However, segmentation criteria are less useful for describing more fundamental and structural aspects of the vacationer's life, which are important for theoretical purposes and for strategic marketing planning (e.g. product development and (re)positioning may be based on an analysis of social and cultural trends in the market). Although segmentation criteria can highlight various aspects of the vacationer's life, without an integrated theory of how to combine them they are like separate pieces of a puzzle. Therefore, more theoretical typologies have been proposed and these have focused either on socio-psychological variables of the vacationer, or on his/her decision-making style. In this paper, we propose a new typology where socio-psychological processes and decision styles are combined. The need for such a typology becomes apparent when one looks at the strengths and weaknesses of existing typologies.

1.1. Socio-psychological processes

In general, socio-psychological typologies offer a more integrated view of the vacationer because they connect descriptive aspects of the vacationer with

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Table 1
Tourist typologies based on segmentation criteria

Author(s)	Major variable(s)	Tourist types
Anderson and Langmeyer (1982)	Age	The under-50 and over-50 travelers
Etzel and Woodside (1982)	Distance traveled	Distant and near-home travelers
Fodness (1992)	Family life cycle	Young couple, young parents, mature parents, mature couple, senior couple
Hsieh et al. (1992)	Activities	Visiting friends and relatives, outdoor sports, sightseeing, full-house activity, entertainment
Lang, O'Leary, and Morrison (1997)	Destination	Within-Asia and out-of-Asia (Taiwanese outbound tourists)
Moscardo et al. (1996)	Travel benefits and activities	Escape/excitement, self-esteem/self-development, family relationships, physical activity, safety-security, self-esteem/social status, escape, relaxation
Shoemaker (1994)	Benefits sought	Get away/family travelers, adventurous/educational travelers, gamblers/fun oriented travelers
Spotts and Mahoney (1991)	Expenditure	Light, medium and heavy spenders
Woodside and Jacobs (1985)	Benefits sought	Rest and relaxation, cultural experiences, family togetherness
Woodside, Cook, and Mindak (1987)	Frequency of travel	Light and heavy travelers

Table 2
Tourist typologies based on socio-psychological variables

Author(s)	Major variable(s)	Tourist types
Cha et al. (1995)	Push factors (motives)	Sport seekers, novelty seekers and family/relaxation seekers
Cohen (1972)	Roles, motives and level of risk aversion/novelty seeking	Drifter, explorer, individual mass and organized mass
Cohen (1979)	Roles, motives and sought experiences	The recreational, the diversionary, the experiential, the experimental and the existential tourist
Davis et al. (1988)	Attitudes, interests and opinions	Five clusters of differing degrees of attitudes towards the state's tourism efforts
Madrigal and Kahle (1994)	Values and lifestyles	External locus of control (sense of belonging and security), enjoyment/excitement, achievement, egocentrism
Mayo and Jarvis (1981)	Psychographics	The 'peace-and-quiet' traveler, the overseas traveler, the historian traveler, the recreational vehicle traveler and the 'travel now/ pay later' traveler
Mazanec (1994)	Socio-styles	Dandy, rocky, business, squadra, protest, scout, pioneer, olvidados, vigilante, romantic, defence, prudent, moralist, citizen, gentry, strict
Plog (1974, 1994)	Personality traits	Psychocentrics and allocentrics (plus intermediate categories: near-psychocentrics, midcentrics, near-allocentrics)
Smith (1989)	Motives and lifestyles	Explorer, elite, offbeat, unusual, incipient mass, mass, charter
Thrane (1997)	Personal values	The modern materialist, the modern idealist, the traditional materialist and the traditional idealist

sociological or psychological variables (see Table 2). Socio-psychological typologies can be based on values and lifestyles (Madrigal & Kahle, 1994; Thrane, 1997), attitudes, interests and opinions (Davis, Allen, & Crosonza, 1988), motives (Cha, McCleary, & Uysal, 1995), or personality types (Plog, 1974). In a 'meta-typology', Plog (1994) identifies eight psychographic/personality dimensions of the tourist: venturesomeness, pleasure-seeking, impulsivity, self-confidence, planfulness, masculinity, intellectualism and people orientation. Of particular importance to the tourism literature has been Cohen's (1972, 1979) work. Based on tourist roles, motives and sought experiences, he developed a four-fold classification of tourist behaviors (i.e. drifter, explorer, individual mass and organized mass). There have been a few attempts to develop and refine this

popular typology (Pearce, 1982; Redfoot, 1984; Wickens, 2002). Mayo and Jarvis (1981) describe five types of travelers: the 'peace-and-quiet', the overseas, the historian, the recreational vehicle and the 'travel now/ pay later' traveler. Finally, general socio-style typologies of US and European consumers have been adapted to tourism (Mazanec, 1994). Other typologies are reviewed by Lowyck, Van Langenhove, and Bollaert (1992) and Swarbrooke and Horner (1999).

While interesting for conceptualization purposes and a more thorough understanding of tourist behavior, socio-psychological typologies lack practical relevance for decision-making in tourism, 'as the implied types are often difficult to identify' (Bargeman, Joh, & Timmermans, 2002, p. 321). A first reason for this may be that many typologies have been built more than 10 years ago,

at a time when the tourism market was not as developed as today and when vacationing was not such an integral part of people's life. Another reason is that most socio-psychological typologies are presented as universal, to be applied to people in all types of decision-making units (DMUs) and all countries. Interpersonal influences in group decision-making and the cultural environment are not taken into account when looking at tourist behavior. In addition, almost all typologies suggest mutually exclusive categories of tourists that do not allow consumers to move between categories in response to personal or situational changes, or to an evolution in their 'vacation career' (Pearce, 1988). A final reason for the lack of practical relevance is that most socio-psychological typologies have not been empirically tested (Mo, Howard, & Havitz, 1993). It is likely that, because of this last reason, existing typologies are rather descriptive, ignoring the gap between stated preferences and actual choices.

1.2. Decision-making styles

Bronner and De Hoog (1985) propose another view on building a more theoretical typology of vacationers. They argue that the way people decide is an important element for segmentation studies. Socio-demographic and socio-psychological variables should be complemented by decision-making variables like information-seeking (Oppedijk van Veen, 1983) and combined they can form a typology of decision styles. Bronner and De Hoog further identify three segments (i.e. nature seekers, sun and beach seekers and culture seekers) based on different socio-demographics, vacation ideas and choice characteristics. They stress that 'differences between people concerning choice characteristics are real. This means that in planning a marketing strategy these differences must be taken into account' (p. 114). Sproule and Kendall (1986) define a consumer decision-making style as 'a mental orientation characterizing a consu-

mer's approach to making choices' (p. 267) and consider it as a basic aspect of the consumer's personality. They also provide empirical support that decision-making styles are largely independent of culture, although this finding was later contradicted by Lysonski, Durvasula, and Zotos (1996). These authors identified seven factors of decision-making profiles of shoppers in four countries and found that 'some of the factors are not applicable in describing decision-making styles in other countries' (p. 14).

Bronner and De Hoog's (1985) proposition to base market segmentation on decision-making styles has been supported by Woodside and Carr (1988), who conclude that 'vacation travelers can be segmented meaningfully by consumer decision-making variables' (p. 2). The latter authors propose the following variables: the alternatives considered, the benefits sought, the decision rules used and the sensitivities to changes in attributes. Much in accordance with this, Hsieh, O'Leary, Morrison, and Chiang (1997) have identified different types of travel decision patterns in the Japanese travel market using a multi-stage segmentation base. Three major criteria are enhanced: travel philosophies (how people think about and prefer to travel in overall), benefits sought and product preferences. They conclude that 'travel decision pattern segmentation is a theoretically and statistically feasible approach to understand and segment travelers' (p. 299). Fodness and Murray (1998) presented a classification of tourist information search strategies, while Bargeman et al. (2002) developed a typology incorporating information on vacation behavior over time using sequence alignment methods and Dutch vacation history data. Those major typologies based on decision-making variables are summarized in Table 3.

While useful for both theoretical and practical purposes, typologies based on decision-making styles tend to consider decision-making variables in isolation and decision style as a personality trait. An exception to

Table 3
Tourist typologies based on decision-making variables

Author(s)	Major variable(s)	Tourist types
Bargeman et al. (2002)	Sequence of decisions (frequency, duration, timing, destination, temporal and spatial sequence, spatial repetition)	Groups I–VIII
Bronner and De Hoog (1985)	Decision styles (socio-demographics, vacation ideas and choice characteristics)	Nature seekers, sun and beach seekers and culture seekers
Fodness and Murray (1998)	Information search strategies	Prepurchase mix, tourist bureau, personal experience, ongoing, on-site, automobile club and travel agency
Hsieh et al. (1997)	Travel philosophies (how people think about and prefer to travel in overall), benefits sought and product preferences	Active/heritage/outdoor sports, reluctant/social escape/outdoor sports, budget/escape/cultural scenic, active package/being and seeing/destination attributes, low-yield and high-yield travelers
Reid and Crompton (1993)	Level of involvement and the ability to differentiate between attributes	Hierarchy-of-effects, dissonance-attribution hierarchy, alternative attribution hierarchy, low involvement hierarchy, single/integrated hierarchy

this is the typology of Reid and Crompton (1993), who developed a taxonomy of five decision-making styles based on the level of involvement and the ability to differentiate between attributes. But apart from this study, there has been no attempt at an integrative empirical typology of vacationers. The present paper extends previous work by providing a typology based on decision-making variables and processes. The typology has emerged from a longitudinal naturalistic study in which vacationers were followed over the year in their decision-making for a summer vacation. It describes decision styles within the larger framework of socio-demographic and socio-psychological criteria. It is hoped that this will avoid the respective deficiencies of theoretical socio-psychological typologies, which have limited relevance for managers and typologies based on segmentation criteria that lack a conceptual orientation (Bargeman et al., 2002). Finally, the typology will be related to major variables and models derived from the decision-making literature. In short, this paper proposes a new typology, which is empirically grounded and which integrates both practical and theoretical variables to give an inclusive view of different vacation decision-making processes (DMP).

2. Method

The vacation DMP of 25 Belgian households was followed for a whole year. Informants were recruited according to theoretical sampling, which means looking for cases that were likely to yield rich and varied information in order to maximize theory development (Strauss & Corbin, 1990). The criterion to enter the study was the intention to go on summer vacation. The sample was varied based on socio-demographic criteria and the four types of vacation DMUs: singles who decide on their own, couples, families with children and groups of friends. Twenty-seven DMUs were initially interviewed in February. Two DMUs were not considered further because they no longer intended to go on vacation. The remaining 25 DMUs were interviewed again in April and 20 of these were interviewed for a third time in June, because their DMP had not been completed in April.

In each interview, informants were asked to talk about three central themes: (1) general vacation and travel behavior, (2) general expectations and motives and (3) current vacation plans and evoked vacation destinations. The interviews were recorded on tape and additional information about the way and the context in which things were said was written down during and after each interview. In-depth interviewing allows for adapting the content and the flow of the interview to each informant, without forcing interviewees into preconceived answer patterns. There is more room for

discovering particular situations and atypical behaviors, which is important for theory generation (Rubin & Rubin, 1995).

This naturalistic longitudinal design helps understanding the context, the complexities and dynamics of the DMP. It avoids problems linked to the intention-behavior discrepancy (Belk, 1985) when hypothetical and not actual decision questions are asked. Moreover, a few studies (van Raaij & Francken, 1984; Moutinho, 1987) have shown that vacation choices involve a long DMP, which takes place over many months.

The analysis and interpretation of the interview transcripts and field notes are based on the grounded theory approach (Glaser & Strauss, 1967), which is 'a qualitative research method that uses a systematic set of procedures to develop an inductively derived grounded theory about a phenomenon' (Strauss & Corbin, 1990, p. 24). These procedures include the concurrent collection and analysis of data and the enhancement of theoretical sensitivity. Categories, patterns and propositions emerge from the coding process of the data and are permanently called into question. Coding is made at three levels (i.e. open, axial and selective coding) from the most descriptive to the most interpretative. In the last years, there have been several examples of a grounded theory approach in tourism research (e.g. Hernandez, Cohen, & Garcia, 1996; Herold, Garcia, & DeMoya, 2001; Riley, 1995; Teare, 1994). Connell and Lowe (1997) have reviewed the application of inductive methods in tourism and hospitality management research.

3. Vacation decision-making

Before turning to the typology, we give a summary of emerging findings regarding the vacation DMP of our sample. A more detailed presentation can be found in Decrop (1999). For all DMUs, vacation decision-making is an ongoing process that is not characterized by unchanging sequential stages and that does not end once a decision is made. For example, the generic decision to go on vacation or not, which is the first 'logical' step in many models (van Raaij & Francken, 1984; Um & Crompton, 1990; Mansfeld, 1992), does not always come first and is even irrelevant for some (i.e. routine) vacationers. In the same way, there is seldom a linear (i.e. sequential and hierarchical) evolution of vacation plans. Lack of involvement and the intervention of situational factors are responsible for many deviations and turnarounds. It also appears that most vacationers are involved in more vacation plans at the same time, which may pertain to different time periods, different vacation modes and/or different types of DMUs.

Emotional factors are particularly powerful in shaping vacation choices. Sometimes, people make their vacation decisions according to momentary moods or emotions. This suggests that, for some informants, the ‘Affective Choice Mode’ (Mittal, 1988) is more relevant than the traditional ‘Information Processing Mode’ (Bettman, 1979) as far as a vacation (an experiential product) is concerned. Daydreaming, nostalgia and anticipation also show how feelings and fantasies are incorporated in the DMP.

For most DMUs, information search is an ongoing process, which can predate the generic decision to go and which does not end after booking. Information search is also less intensive and purposive than usually assumed (e.g. Bettman, 1979; Mathieson & Wall, 1982; Mansfeld, 1992). Information search is more supportive for daydreaming than for actual choice. Information is often collected incidentally and passively and it is often not used when collected, but stocked for later possible use.

In general, vacation decision-making is often triggered off incidentally through information collection or opportunities. A lot of late decisions are also found, which can be explained by risk reduction, situational variables, availability (opportunism), loyalty and personality. Following Bettman, Johnson, and Payne (1991) general properties of choice heuristics, one should say that vacationers’ decision strategies are characterized by a limited amount of processing, selective processing (the amount of processing is not consistent across alternatives or attributes), qualitative rather than quantitative reasoning and attribute-based and non-compensatory rules (as contrasted with alternative-based and compensatory). Finally, some structure can be found in vacation decision-making. While vacationers tend to be optimistic and idealistic at the outset of their vacation plans, they become more realistic over time. This is accompanied by a growing commitment to choice, which is in line with Mansfeld’s (1994) value stretch model. The intervention of contextual factors is the major reason for this shift: contextual facilitators are first considered while contextual inhibitors are taken into account later (Um, 1990).

In the introduction of this paper, we discussed the possible relevance of demographic and socio-psychological variables as contextual factors in the DMP of vacationers. From the data, four major types of contextual influence can be distinguished: environmental, personal, interpersonal and situational factors (see Fig. 1). First, environmental factors such as culture, the social network and the geo-physical environment are structural elements that encompass all other factors. Second, a distinction is made between primary and secondary personal influences. Age, family situation, occupation, personality and lifestyle are the primary roots from which the other personal variables originate.

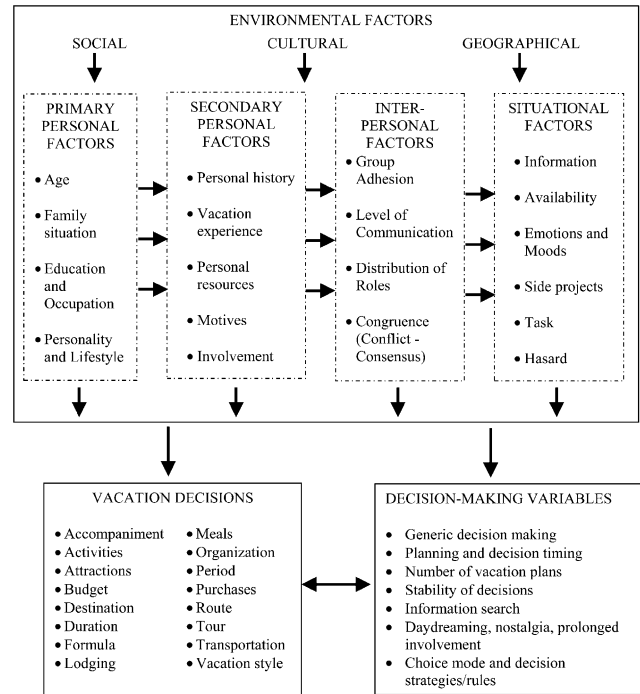


Fig. 1. Contextual factors in vacation decision-making.

Third, personal factors affect group decision-making, which includes a lot of interpersonal influences. Fourth, situational factors come into play when the vacationer makes his/her decisions.

Some of these contextual factors are specific to a time and place, while others are enduring structural conditions that intervene either as facilitators or inhibitors on vacation decisions and decision-making variables. Contextual influences also have different weights across vacationers. Overall, couples are the least dependent on context, because interpersonal constraints are limited between two persons. Groups of friends are the most dependent, because contextual influences can vary significantly across group members. Singles do not have any interpersonal constraint but may have stronger personal inhibitions, such as averting the risks connected with traveling alone. In families, personal, interpersonal and situational contextual factors come into play.

4. A new typology of vacationers

Given the variation in decision-making styles, one cannot speak of one universal vacation DMP. Depending on the project, six types of vacationers can be described: habitual, rational, hedonic, opportunistic, constrained and adaptable. These will be discussed below. For each type of vacationer, the number of

DMUs is listed within parentheses, describing how often the type was dominant in the DMU.

4.1. *The habitual vacationer*

Habitual vacationers ($n = 3$) are slightly involved and repeat the same vacation behavior almost every year (e.g. going to the same place). They are ruled by habit due to their personality or structural influences (e.g. owning a cottage). In many instances, this type of vacationer is risk averse: they cannot afford to ‘miss’ their vacation and like to feel at home at the destination. Optimizing the vacation time is another possible goal: by always going to the same spot, they avoid wasting time on familiarizing with a new environment. It should further be noted that habitual decision-making often pertains to particular vacation sub-decisions. For example, for an older couple, the choice of transportation has never been discussed since they always go on vacation by car. This is not to say that other vacation decision aspects are automatic.

Habitual vacationers follow decision rules in an unconscious and routine way. They hardly prepare their trip and limit their information to new possible activities in the familiar region. Habitual vacationers may be the ‘victims’ of their passive and inertial personality: while they may first have an intention to break with routine and fantasize about alternative destinations, they seem incapable of making it happen. Long-term planning is a difficult task for them. In contrast, they are pragmatic and prefer certainty, even if this means the renunciation of potentially better solutions:

André (M, 40, engineer, family with three teenagers): at a certain moment, we found ourselves in front of different options: either we let go the possibility of going to Sweden because other interested people begin to appear, or...and thus one of the options, let's say the one most worked out disappeared and we ended up in front of very vague projects and finally we told ourselves ‘well, let's take the option we know and we will search better next year’.

In the literature, habitual decision-making is characterized by little or no information seeking and little or no evaluation of alternatives. Repeated purchases and brand loyalty are the major consequences of a habitual DMP (Jacoby & Kyner, 1973). A lot of product decisions have been presented to involve habit as a simplifying strategy when consumers are lowly involved in the category or when they want to reduce risk. However, to our knowledge, vacation decision-making is rarely presented as a habitual process. In contrast, tourism has been depicted as a high involvement (shopping) product with high consumer commitment and a complex DMP (Moutinho, 1987; Swarbrooke & Horner, 1999).

4.2. *The (bounded) rational vacationer*

Risk aversion has a strong influence on the vacation decisions and DMP of rational vacationers ($n = 7$). First, it affects generic tradeoff choices: thrifty, they are not ready to go on vacation at any cost. Next, risk aversion often results in brand loyalty for particular aspects of the trip. For example, a single vacationer always books her trips in the same travel agency. Further, rational vacationers are not daydreamers nor fantasizers, but careful and realistic decision makers.

Rational vacationers start thinking about their vacation quite early (before January/February). They are characterized by careful planning and take facilitating and inhibiting constraints into account as they appear. This is not to say that final vacation decisions are taken early, but a booking is made as soon as the context makes it possible. Choices are well thought-out and predictable: the final destination is always one of the first evoked destinations; well-defined decision criteria and strategies are used. For example, in a group of adult friends:

Patrick (M, 43, attorney, group of friends): We did that, we handed out a kind of table with a few criteria which had to be rated saying: ‘that is something that is important for me, the comfort of the accommodation, the food, the climate, the price...’ We established parameters. And in relation to these parameters, we saw for example that budget was rated the highest [...] And there are other criteria... We saw, for example, that comfort or the quality of food were not important criteria.

Bounded rationality (March & Simon, 1958; Cyert & March, 1963) is the prevailing paradigm here. Rational vacationers do not go at all ends to choose the best possible vacation alternative but rather an alternative that is ‘good enough’. An emerging reason for not being purely rational is incrementalism: choosing the best alternative is not truly necessary since poor decisions may be changed the next (vacation) time. Further, informants do not search for that much information as they have limited information-processing abilities. However, information collection is more important and purposive than for other types of vacationers. Preparation is quite extensive and occurs before booking and not on the spot. Everything has to be planned before leaving in order not to miss important aspects of the trip (e.g. historical sights) or to avoid bad surprises (e.g. no vacancy). During the trip, rational vacationers take care that everything happens according to plans or, at least, the situation is kept under volitional control (‘if we did participate in all those additional activities, it is just because we wanted it’).

This type of vacation decision-making can be paralleled with the problem-solving paradigm in consumer

behavior (Engel, Kollat, & Blackwell, 1973; Howard & Sheth, 1969). Decision-making starts with a problem within the DMU (i.e. a need or desire to go on vacation) and the vacationer tries to solve the problem by planning a course of action to satisfy this need or desire. Information search, evaluation of vacation alternatives, consumption (rather than purchase) and post-experience evaluation are the major decision-making steps. However, even rational vacationers do not go through each of these steps sequentially. For example, they may first make a destination decision before looking for information about it. Therefore, speaking of thoughtful or reasoned action (Fishbein, 1980) is more appropriate.

4.3. *The hedonic vacationer*

Hedonic vacationers ($n = 4$) take delight in thinking, dreaming and talking about their vacation because this enhances their pleasure and emotional arousal. As vacation involvement is very strong, they grasp any occasion to collect tourist information. They do not hesitate to prompt their fellows to go on vacation and to recommend particular destinations. They are so optimistic that they often neglect the importance of situational constraints: emotional drives are stronger than pragmatic concerns. As a consequence, hedonic vacationers rehearse both planning and experiencing their dream trip, although it is never made or substituted by a proxy destination experience. That is why one could speak of 'surrogate' vacationers. For those vacationers, the shift from dream to reality is very pronounced: dreamt destinations are considered first, but the evoked set becomes more realistic over time. However, the final destination has nothing to do with the first evoked destinations. This focus on daydreaming and the vacation experience and not only on the DMP is supported by Hirschman and Holbrook (1982) and Holbrook and Hirschman (1982).

For the hedonic vacationer, information search seems to be a better indicator of ideals and preferences than of actual choices. For example, a 40-year-old mother of three children gathered loads of information on Brittany but finally chose another destination (Jura), which she knew hardly anything about. When realizing that the dreamt vacation will not be possible, this vacationer went back to a more feasible option in order to avoid frustration. This appeared to be very hard:

Anne (F, 41, journalist, family with three children): And I try to think less about it! Otherwise I have stomach ache! Actually, one whole Easter week we had everything to leave and we did not leave! Thus, I try to think less about it, so I am not frustrated. My oldest daughter told me: 'I prefer that we say that we do not leave but then we leave in the end than the

opposite!' She just told me that two days ago! The idea is always intimately present! I am always sensitive to everything that happens in the regions we like. I continue to read, to dream... My daughter gave me a tape about Romania, about touristic Romania precisely: a document that lasts thirty minutes. But I take it especially in ethnological terms... It is very interesting, because the people who watched it always want to go visit Romania! We have been there several times! Thus some kind of feeling still remains, which we try to escape from because we should not have too strong illusions!

Hedonic vacationers are also characterized by hedonic consumption, as illustrated by the following examples. A single woman never brings souvenirs because she considers her trips as pleasurable experiences, which do not need to leave material marks. Another informant wants to go back to Rome because of the pleasure of dawdling and dreaming (imagining speeches in the Forum) when visiting its historical sites.

4.4. *The opportunistic vacationer*

Opportunistic vacationers ($n = 5$) do not think or talk a lot about vacation. As they minimize vacation planning and preparation, they could be considered as unplanned vacationers. They are unplanned either as a strategy, due to contextual pressures or to a lack of vacation involvement. First, they are willingly waiting for a social or financial opportunity or they anticipate potential situational constraints (e.g. children's summer activities, school results, time of vacation pay, or a threatening illness). Heavy professional activities and the resulting lack of leisure time are a second reason for being unplanned and opportunistic. Third, personal factors such as the lack of involvement or the passive ('wait-and-see') nature of the vacationer come into play.

Decisions here stem from the co-occurrence of a need and a choice solution, which is much in line with the 'garbage can' decision model (Cohen, March, & Olsen, 1972; Wilson & Wilson, 1988). This model suggests that decisions are analogous to garbage cans into which problems, solutions, choice opportunities and decision makers are dumped and connected with each other through temporal proximity. As a consequence, almost any solution can be associated with any problem, provided they are evoked at the same time. Information is limited, not actively searched and often not used. For example, the opportunistic vacationer may find him/herself in Vienna for 2 days, with only the prior knowledge that Vienna is in Austria. However, s/he is always listening to ideas and propositions from social and commercial networks.

Opportunistic vacationers do not use any well-defined strategy in making their vacation decisions. Decisions

result from opportunities or special occasions. This may be an advertised commercial offer, or propositions or invitations by family and friends. Vacation choices are made haphazardly during discussions, meetings, walks, or phone calls. Waiting for opportunities results in very late but sudden decisions and bears the risk of not going on vacation at all. Since flexibility is important for them, vacation plans and evoked sets are not very stable; turnarounds make destination choices particularly unpredictable:

Thierry (M, 28, sales rep, couple): But if an opportunity comes out from now to the end of the year, it is very possible... (from now to vacation time, sorry) that we will take this opportunity. I do not know... if we have an opportunity to go to Italy because for one reason or another, we have a house, or rather there is a friend who rents one house and who proposes us to go with him, well we will go to Italy.

Finally, the data suggest that opportunistic vacationers combine different options from plans and situations in their trips. For example, a family plans to combine a visit to one of their children vacationing in Spain with a visit to long-time friends in Montpellier (France) and showing the 'Pont de Normandie' (France) to their children while coming back home.

4.5. *The constrained vacationer*

Constrained vacationers ($n = 4$) undergo vacation decision-making rather than controlling it. Some vacationers are weighted down by contextual inhibitors (see Fig. 1) such as limited financial resources or the intervention of situational variables (e.g. house moving, health problems). Some of these constraints only pertain to particular individuals within the DMU. For example, members of a group of friends find it hard to make final vacation decisions due to conflicting individual preferences. Conflicts may arise within the DMU and this may make vacationers unwilling as they are forced to make the trip and visit certain destinations because other members of the DMU demand it. This is especially true for women and children. For example, an old widow is forced to go on vacation against her will, because her son wants her to recover from a depression. Children are often constrained vacationers because the destination chosen by their parents does not match their preferences. Some women also become unwilling vacationers when they realize that the choice of accommodation (i.e. renting an apartment) will force them to do the same housework as at home. The political model of decision-making (Pettigrew, 1973; Pfeffer, 1981) can readily be applied to constrained vacationers. This model contends that most human decisions are not individual but rather

involve groups, which may lead to conflicts in preferences and identities and a struggle for power.

As a consequence, constrained vacationers are not really involved in a DMP; information search is very limited and passive, if existing at all. In contrast with hedonic vacationers, the destination evoked set is quite stable and realistic right from the outset of plans:

Jacques (M, 43, disabled, family with three children): We dream about vacations and we know that there are vacations..., that we have dreams that we will...

Chantal (F, 35, domestic help): ...never do it.

Jacques: ...never carry out. For example, the United States is a country that I dream of going, that it would be the most beautiful. But, I know that I will never go.

Finally, the particular case of a group of friends is worth mentioning. Each group member proposes up to three destinations and the final destination is drawn from a hat. These vacationers are constrained because they are bound to the result of the drawing even though they do not like the destination. There is a moral commitment to that random decision based on group adhesion, such as explained by the 26-year-old speaker of the group: 'We have already discussed about that: thus if there is someone who does not want, well he does not come. Generally, everybody comes because we are a very united group from the army'.

4.6. *The adaptable vacationer*

This type of vacationers is inspired by Payne, Bettman, and Johnson (1993) 'adaptive decision maker'. Adaptable vacationers ($n = 3$) like vacationing and traveling. Thinking about vacation is a continuous flow as they always have more vacation projects in mind. Those projects are often carried through because these vacationers adapt their plans according to the situation, which means that they often revise their decisions and modify their behavior. Final decisions are taken lately because they wait for the best adaptation of their vacation plans. Adaptable vacationers go on vacation sometimes with their family (including children), sometimes with some friends, or sometimes with their partner for a romantic trip. Each time, decisions and decision-making style are adapted to the particularities of those different DMUs. This is in line with March's (1994) contention that 'any decision process involves a collection of individuals and groups who are simultaneously involved in other things' (p. 198).

Adaptable vacationers do not use well-defined decision strategies. Decision-making is characterized by

much flexibility, which makes choices very unpredictable:

Pierre (M, 43, independent manager, couple): We have some friends who would like to go to Scotland. Err... to Scotland, I say yes: if finally the decision is taken, if they want to leave at the same period as us, we will leave together. There you go, we will go there because of them. If not, I would like to take my wife to discover the Nordic countries which I have already visited and I would like to make her discover that. Actually nothing has been... I am ready to change, you know.

Interviewer: You are ready to change?

Pierre: Yes, I mean that if another project takes shape, we will change. It is not...

As we do not reserve anything, nothing has been...

Adaptable vacationers do not prepare the trip in too much depth as flexibility is also relevant during the trip itself. As a consequence, adaptable vacationers are independent travelers who hate group constraints and organized tours. While having some anchor points (must-see sights), they leave room for improvisation and the adaptation of plans:

Françoise (F, 30, teacher, group of friends): It is anyway the rule that we always have together, it is that whenever we went to a place, if there was a place that we liked, we did not hesitate to stay longer, ready to give up another thing. Thus, actually we never have something totally precise, planned, for which we cannot change the rule if we see other interesting things.

The previous findings confirm Payne et al.'s (1993) contention that people are adaptive in that they use a variety of strategies to solve decision problems, contingent upon task and context (social) factors. Strategy selection may be seen as 'the result of a compromise between the desire to make the most accurate decision and the desire to minimize cognitive effort' (p. 248).

5. Conclusion

According to Hunt (1991), typologies used in marketing should be 'intersubjectively unambiguous', 'mutually exclusive' and 'collectively exhaustive' (pp. 187–188). The typology presented here scores well on the first criterion: the naturalistic longitudinal design allows for a rich description of each type. This makes it easy to identify a type at various stages of the DMP. With respect to the second criterion, this typology is not mutually exclusive at the DMU level, since there may be individual differences within DMUs. Even within one individual, different types of DMPs may be followed

depending on opportunities, emotions, etc., as illustrated by the following quotation:

Martine (F, 37, teacher, single): The destination, well that depends. There are some trips which I have in reserve and I wait to find the best trip or when the prices have lowered; then there are the ones that I fall in love with. Sometimes, I may have not even considered any destination and then suddenly...

Although DMUs and individuals may mix decision-making styles, informants could easily be classified in one particular style within each vacation project. This means that the typology is mutually exclusive at the vacation project level. As for the third criterion, the typology is exhaustive within the boundaries of the small sample of Belgian vacationers. The six types provide a good description of all encountered cases.

The need for relativism is the major theoretical lesson from this research. There is not only one but a plurality of vacation DMPs. Six types of vacationers have been depicted based on personal, social and decision-making variables. This breaks with existing models which propose one typical, i.e. bounded rational (March & Simon, 1958), vacation decision process. Our findings have shown that there is a need to 'soften' traditional tenets which characterize vacation decision-making as high involvement (Moutinho, 1987; Swarbrooke & Horner, 1999), extensive problem solving and information search (Middleton, 1994) and a sequential evolution of plans starting from the generic decision to go on vacation (van Raaij & Francken, 1984; Mansfeld, 1992). More particularly, one should pay more attention to adaptability and opportunism in vacation decision-making. Adaptability (Payne et al., 1993) has major consequences on decision timing, information search and the predictability of choices. Another aspect deserving more attention is the daydreaming of hedonic vacationers (Hirschman & Holbrook, 1982). A lot of information about tourist destinations is collected for fantasizing and stirring the imagination. At the same time, that information is hardly predictive of actual vacation choices. So one may wonder whether daydreaming is an end in itself, or whether it serves some function during the actual vacation experience. Further research should clarify this since the informants of this study were not contacted during their vacation. Finally, the constrained vacation type shows that people do not always feel in control in choosing and planning their vacation. In the sample, this concerned women and children the most, who often felt forced into supporting certain decisions, becoming disinterested in the vacation as a result. Again, the implications of this finding for the actual vacation experience and family relations during the vacation deserve more attention.

At the managerial level, tour-operators and travel agents should benefit from the opportunistic nature of

decision-making of some vacationers by keeping in touch with them and making them offers (early booking or last-minute discounts). Active steps are particularly recommended because vacationers prove to be waiting for and not purposefully searching for information. The adaptability of vacationers should also be taken into account. As vacationers are involved in more vacation projects at the same time with different needs and desires, they should not be put in one exclusive segment. This typology of vacationers based on DMPs could therefore be used in addition to more traditional segmentation bases. Given the stress on the DMP, this typology is more likely to be applied for the purpose of product communication than for the purpose of product development. It gives indications about vacation involvement and planning, decision timing, the amount and type of information search, etc. All those elements could be used in promotion campaigns. Finally, it should be noted that vacationers may like more flexibility in their planning, that they may value product information as much for its utility as for its ability to stir up the imagination and that the actual vacation package may have to deal with uninvolved and even unwilling vacationers. These issues could be exploited when developing packages and organized tours.

Probably the major question about this research pertains to the external validity or transferability of emerging findings. Two dimensions of transferability need being discussed: statistical generalization and the ethnicity of informants. In this paper, a typology of vacationers has been built inductively from the study of a phenomenon situated in a particular context. Although analytical generalization of some emerging findings is possible, statistical generalization is not possible because of the theoretical (non-random) sampling procedure and the small sample size. If statistical generalization were desired, the emerging propositions of this paper could be tested on larger representative samples. For example, it would be interesting to investigate whether a typology similar to this new typology of vacationers could be derived from quantitative survey data using factor analytic or clustering techniques. The present study has put forward many propositions that could be converted into questions to generate those data.

The issue of the transferability in terms of the ethnicity of the decision makers also has to be raised since the sample of this study only consists of Belgian vacationers. However, the emergence of a 'touristic' culture, as opposed to a 'nationalistic' culture, has been put into light for western countries from which most tourists emanate (McIntosh, Goeldner, & Brent Ritchie, 1995; de Vulpian, 1989). As a result, international tourists tend to have similar profiles: 'The international [tourism] market is largely made up of middle-income people, including the more prosperous minority of the

working class, who normally live in large cities and earn their living in managerial, professional, white-collar, supervisory and skilled occupations' (McIntosh et al., 1995). Moreover, Sproles and Kendall (1986) argue that decision-making styles are largely independent of the culture but are rather descriptive of a personal orientation. Therefore, the six types of vacationers presented in this paper could be found in different parts of the world, of course with different distributions. In general, the Belgian society is reported to be a 'miniature Europe', where 'most general economic and consumption tendencies that have a grip over Europe, also reign the Belgian society' (Gijbrecchts, Swinnen, & van Waterschoot, 1995, p. 389). However, on one particular point Belgians have been reported to be different: they are seen as more risk averse (Hofstede, 1983). Since risk aversion may lead to higher involvement levels, more information gathering, avoiding conflicts and safer choices, the description of the habitual, rational and constrained vacationer types may be somewhat exaggerated when looked at from a culture that is less risk averse.

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